

driver, CPI(M) took credit for the few things that have gone right with the Government even as it heaped blame on the Congress for everything that had gone wrong. On the issues of the National Rural Employment Guarantee (NREG), Tribal Forest Rights Act and the Right to Information Act, CPI(M) appropriated all the feathers for its cap even as it patted itself on the back for stopping the UPA Government in its tracks on issues like public sector disinvestment, labour law amendments, pension fund changes, opening up of the retail sector, reforms of banking and insurance etc. But where blame had to be shared, the party tried

But it was on issues like Nandigram that CPI(M)'s ambivalence was on display. Even as it admitted the West Bengal Government's "administrative mistakes" in handling the issue, it spared no efforts to justify the setting up of a chemical hub at Nandigram.

The West Bengal Government had set up an exhibition too at the party congress narrating the "heinous crimes committed by the Maoist-Trinamool combine" on the people of Nandigram and the CPI(M) cadres in particular. The exhibition, without mentioning a word on the atrocities committed by the

a longer process to put an end to it completely. All the vices and ills of society reflect on our party too. We are not sanyasis to be above all these problems. But we shall overcome them," says Pillai.

The party trumpeted the fact that there has been a 13.18 per cent growth in its membership since its 18th party meet three years ago, even as its hopes of establishing a pan-Indian presence appear to be a distant dream. "We have impressive growth. But it continues to be uneven and is restricted mainly to states where we are traditionally strong," says Yechury, admitting that almost 90 per cent of the new

The Left hopes to rope in outfits like the Samajwadi Party and Telugu Desam Party and thinks some secular parties "trapped" in the NDA will answer its call.



TIRED TESTED FRONT: (L-R) Amar Singh, Babulal Marandi, Chandrababu Naidu, Mulayam, Bardhan and Karat

to make sure that the Congress was left to carry the can alone. Ever since Finance Minister P. Chidambaram has announced the farmer loans waiver, CPI(M) has reserved much of its ire for the Government over inflation, which is hovering around the 7 per cent mark. Along with CPI and other "like-minded" parties, it plans to take to the streets if the Government is unable to apply the brakes on runaway inflation. As a marker of the growing divide between the Left and the Congress, the issue of rising prices came second only to that of the Indo-US nuclear cooperation agreement.

Government or CPI(M), showcased all the details of the party cadres who became "martyrs" at Nandigram.

The party congress also admitted its failure to root out factionalism—especially in Kerala—even after the 18th party meeting had issued stern warnings against it. The Politburo had to intervene many times in the state to curb the tendency and even suspended—for the first time—top leaders Achuthanandan and CPI(M) state Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan from the Politburo. "We have made considerable progress in curbing factionalism in the last three years. But it takes

members belonged to Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Tripura—states where the party already has a moderate to significant presence. But along with the growth in membership, the party has also seen a dropout rate of 7.73 per cent since the last congress. More worrying for the party is the fact that in Kerala, where it gets to rule every alternate term, the dropout rate is 10.62 per cent. An alarming statistic from a state that—CPI(M) never tires of reminding anyone who would care to listen—is the first place anywhere in the world to get an elected communist government. ■